

Your Guide to the New Website

The program you know and love, with a friendlier website. This little guide walks you through the few things you'll do each season. There is nothing to install, nothing to memorize, and nothing you can break.

What's new

It's the same Holiday Project — same mission, same partners, same warmth. What changed is the website. Families can now apply online with one short, simple form (the phone line and the paper application are still there for anyone who prefers them). And you have a private, easy control panel — we call it the **admin** — for running the season.

Since the last version of this guide, the website changed again to match how you actually run things — every one of these came straight from you:

Eligibility is all yours again. The income-check math and its flags are gone — you verify every application by hand, the way you always have. The income families report is still right there on each application for you to read.

Two papers: packing slips and pick up notices. The *packing slip* (for the volunteers, one per page with ruled note lines) carries the household's details, each person's sizes, doll choice, and a *Gifts to pack* column — that column prints whatever is in each person's "Gifts / toys wanted" boxes, so fix those first under *Edit household members* (add or delete items, swap anything you're out of) and the slip becomes your final packing list. The mailed *pick up notice* is a copy of your paper form — name, ID#, pickup day, and the location rules only, three to a page with cut lines — from the new **Print pickup slips to mail** button. Each application page also has its own **Print pickup slip** button, next to Print packing slip, for one family at a time. The date on the notice fills in from the Pickup days screen — match each town to its day first, or the date line prints blank. And for your big towns that pick up over more than one day (Boscobel, Platteville): make each session its own day, then use the **Pickup day for this family** choice on any application to put that family on the right one — everything printed follows it. Income, good deeds, and your private notes never appear on either.

Two applications, just like your paper world. The Apply page now asks families to pick: *Family Household* (children under 18) or *Elderly/Disabled Household* (over 65, or receiving Social Security or SSI). The elderly one is short — no children's sizes or gifts — it sets the 2500 routing on its own, and its approval email says a Christmas card with food and gift cards is coming. Everyone's income goes in its Benefits section, matching your paper form: the Social Security and SSI amounts each ask "*Who receives it?*" — that's where a wife's or a disabled son's benefits appear, and the form now points applicants there plainly. Family applications that include someone 65 or older get a gentle "65+ in household" note so you can split them out if they should get their own card — and ones that include a disabled person get a matching "Disabled person in household" note. A family with children under 18 always stays a Family household (regular gifts and pickup), even when a parent is disabled; only childless households go to the Christmas-card mail list. And the mailed list gained a *Print mailing labels* button for the Christmas-card envelopes.

Your adoption program lives here now. Mark an approved family as adopted right on their application — who adopted them, the contact person, phone, and address — and the website emails the family your adoption note (no pickup slip in December; the adopter will contact you by December 7th to set up pickup dates and times; keep your phone working), takes them off the packing slips, and keeps your letters list on the new *Adoptions* page. Your timeline works exactly as you described: approve families normally as applications come in, then mark them

adopted whenever an adoption request form arrives — October, November, whenever. To send the adopter their family's slip, use the family's own *Print packing slip for the adopter* button (print it, or print-to-PDF and email it) — the packers' pile never includes them. It only allows any of this for families who said Yes to sharing with a sponsor.

Type a note for the packers — no penmanship needed. Each application now has a *Packing note* box. Whatever you type there prints on that family's packing slip ("Note for packers: ..."), in clean type — like "please choose toys suited for a child with special needs." Your private notes box is separate and still never prints anywhere. One habit worth keeping: every box on the application saves with its own button — press *Save packing note* (or the box's own Save) before you leave the page, or the typing is lost.

Families can choose a doll. The application asks, for each child, whether they'd like a White doll or a Non-White doll. The choices appear on the application and in the Special Gift column of your spreadsheet.

Your card tallies live on the website now. Each application has a place to mark the Thanksgiving card (the list counts them toward 30 for you), food cards or certificates, and gift cards, with their amounts.

The Excel download is your spreadsheet. Same columns, same order as the sheet you keep by hand — plus a second button that downloads everything, as a backup.

Every application remembers its changes. A *History* list at the bottom of each application writes down every change on its own — what changed, when, and by whom — and a link shows the application exactly as the family first sent it. Nothing for you to do; it just keeps the record.

The year's numbers, ready for the Board. A new *Season summary* page adds everything up for you — families served by town, the card tallies with dollar totals — on one printable page. And if the same family applies twice (online and on paper, say), the website quietly points it out so you can compare before deciding.

Signing in — no password to remember

Instead of a password, the website emails you a private sign-in link. You click the link, and you're in. That's it.

- 1 Open your web browser and go to grantcountyholidayproject.org/admin
- 2 Type your email address and press **“Email me a sign-in link.”**
- 3 Open your email. You'll have a message with a button that says **“Sign me in.”** Click it. (If you don't see it, check your Junk or Spam folder.)
- 4 You're in — and you'll stay signed in for about 30 days, so you rarely have to do this.

Good to know: the link works for 15 minutes and only once, just to keep things safe. If it expires, simply ask for a new one.

Finding your way around

Across the top of every admin page is a green menu. Click any word to go there:



Two buttons sit in the top corner on every page: **“View the website”** shows you exactly what families see, and **“Sign out”** logs you off when you're finished.

How pickup numbers work now

The website uses your assigned-numbers system. Each town owns its own hundreds, the first family from a town gets the town's number itself, and the next family gets the one after — 1600, then 1601, and so on. The number is assigned the moment you approve, and it goes wherever you need it: the list, the packing slips, and your Excel download.

100s–2300s The towns, each with their own block — Blue River 100s, Muscoda 200s, Lancaster 800s, Platteville 1500s, Fennimore 1600s, and so on, just like your sheet.

2400s **Stragglers** — the checkbox on each application, and it is always your call: the website never marks anyone a straggler on its own. Use it for applications that arrive after their town is packed — or too close to packing day for a mailed slip to reach them in time.

2500s **Elderly and disabled** — they're mailed their gift and food cards, never packed, and never appear on packing slips.

You can always change a number by hand. Every application has a “Pickup number” box — type any number you like (that's also how the little “Kids without toys” numbers work) and press **Save number**. The website simply makes sure no two families ever share a number.

If a town ever runs out of numbers, the website tells you plainly and you type one in yourself. Nothing ever gets stuck.

The main things you'll do

Open or close applications for the season

On the **Home** page you'll see whether applications are OPEN or CLOSED, with one big button to switch it. Open it whenever your season begins — the day is yours to choose (for 2026 you picked September 20th, since adoptions start early). Close it when the season is done. Put the opening date in This year's news so families know when to come. While it's closed, families see a kind message pointing them to the phone line and the paper form.

Review the families who applied

- 1 Click **Applications this year**. The tabs show who still needs review, who's approved, and who's been denied. Each family's line shows the day they applied.
- 2 Click a family's name to read their full application — including exactly when it arrived, everyone in the household, their jobs and income, and their good deed.
- 3 Check the income and the good deed the way you always have — the application shows every job, wage, and benefit the family reported, and their pay-it-forward story, all in one place. The website never judges any of it; eligibility is yours alone.
- 4 Use **“Approve and email them”** or **“Deny and email them”** — the family gets a friendly note automatically, and the page remembers the date and time you decided. (There are also “without email” buttons.) Approving assigns the family's pickup number from their town's block.
- 5 Use **“Print packing slip”** for the volunteers' slip, and **“Download list for Excel”** to get the list as a spreadsheet.

Where is the approval letter? The website sends it as an email the moment you press an “email them” button — there is nothing for you to write. Family approvals say: *“Good news - your Grant County Holiday Project application has been approved. Watch your mail and email for your pickup slip, which will have your pickup date in December. Please bring your pickup slip with you.”* Elderly/Disabled approvals say: *“You have been found eligible for the Grant County Holiday Project Elderly/Disabled program. Your gifts are a Christmas card containing a food and a gift card. You should receive the card the second week in December.”* Denials say: *“Thank you for applying to the Grant County Holiday Project. After review, we are not able to approve your application this season. Applications are denied for one of the following reasons: Excess income · No children under 18 living in the household · Receiving benefits from another program · Someone else has already applied for the children”* — all four reasons every time, never the specific one, just like your paper slip. Every email begins “Hello {first name}” and ends with the message-line number. If someone gave no email address (it's optional on the Elderly/Disabled application), the “email them” buttons simply don't appear — approve without email and, if you'd like them told, copy these words into a mailed note.

See one town at a time — and the mail list

- 1 On **Applications this year**, find the **“Show town”** dropdown. Pick a town and press **Show**.
- 2 You'll see just that town's families, in pickup-number order — ready for distributors, or for answering “who in Platteville receives help.” The Excel download and **every print button** — the list, the packing slips, and the pickup slips to mail — follow whatever view you picked. That's how you print one town's stack while packing it, or just the stragglers' late pile, without ever reprinting everyone.
- 3 Pick **“Elderly & disabled (mailed)”** instead to see your mail list, with addresses, ready to print — and press **“Print mailing labels”** there for Christmas-card envelope labels on standard Avery 30-per-sheet label paper. Glance at the preview first: a very long address can get trimmed to keep the labels lined up.
- 4 Pick **“Stragglers”** to see the late applications you've marked with the straggler checkbox — their own list by themselves, for the end of the project.
- 5 Pick **“Adopted”** to see every family you've adopted out this season — and the Excel download follows, so you can pull just that list too.

Enter a paper application

When a paper application arrives in the mail, you can type it into the website so everything lives in one list.

- 1 On **Applications this year**, press **“Enter a paper application.”**
- 2 Copy from the paper into the boxes. **Only the name and town are required** — leave anything blank that's blank on the paper, even if the application is incomplete. Enter 0 for a wage or age that isn't filled in.
- 3 Set the **date received**, and if you've already written a pickup number on the paper, type it in its box.
- 4 Each child has a **Doll** box now (No doll, White doll, or Non-White doll), so copy that straight from the paper. Anything else with no box — has a car, a Box number — goes in your private **Notes**, right on the form.
- 5 Press **“Save this application.”** Nothing is ever emailed to the family from this screen, and you can approve or deny it afterward just like an online one. When one late family gets approved, print their packing slip right from their own page — no need to reprint anyone else's.

Two similar names, two different jobs: this button is for *typing in* a filled-out paper form. The **Paper application** item in the green menu is where you upload the *blank* PDF that families download to fill out by hand.

Track the Thanksgiving, food, and gift cards

The first 30 families to apply each season get a Thanksgiving card — and now the website keeps the tally with you.

- 1 On a family's page, find the **Cards given** section (near your Notes).
- 2 Check **"Thanksgiving card given"** when you hand one out. The top of **Applications this year** always shows *"Thanksgiving cards: X of 30 given"* so you never have to count.
- 3 When you give a food card or certificate, or gift cards, check those boxes too and type the dollar amounts. Press **"Save cards."**

Nothing here is automatic — it's simply your tally, remembered, and it flows straight into your spreadsheet's Thanksgiving and card columns.

Adopt out a family

- 1 Open an approved family's application. If they answered Yes to sharing with a sponsor, you'll see the **Adoption** section.
- 2 Type who is adopting them — the organization or family, the contact person, phone, and mailing address — then press **"Mark adopted and email them"** (or "without email"). The family gets your note: they've been adopted, no pickup slip, someone will contact them before December 10th.
- 3 That's it — they come off the packing slips automatically, show an **Adopted** tag in your list, and appear on the **Adoptions** page (green menu): your list of adopters with their contact details, ready to print for next year's letters.

The website protects the family's choice: if they said No to sharing, the adoption section stays closed until you change their answer in Edit details — so no family's information is ever shared against their word.

Print the year's numbers for the Board

- 1 Click **Season summary** in the green menu.
- 2 The whole year is already added up for you: applications received, families served by town, the people count, and every card tally with its dollar total. Nothing to fill in — the numbers come straight from your applications list, always current.
- 3 Press **“Print this page”** and hand it to the Board. Use the season picker to look back at past years for the audit.

Update this year's news, gifts list, and pickup schedule

Click **This year's news** to edit what families read on the home page, and **Pickup schedule** to set the pickup days and towns. Type in the boxes and press **Save** — the website updates right away, no waiting.

At the bottom of the Pickup schedule page there's a new section: **“Which day does each town pick up?”** If you match towns to days there, every printed packing slip fills in its family's date automatically — no more writing it 300 times. Leave a town on **“Not set”** and its slips print with a blank date, exactly like before. Your choice, town by town.

Put up the paper applications

Click **Paper application** and upload this year's printable PDFs — there are two slots now, one for the **Family** application and one for the **Elderly/Disabled** application. Those are the files families download when they'd rather fill it out by hand.

Keep the donor list and record donations

- 1 Click **Donors**. Search for a donor, or add a new one at the bottom.
- 2 Click a donor's name to open them, then record what they gave — a date, an amount, or an item.
- 3 The top of the page shows this year's total. Use the **year** box there to look back at a past year.

Read messages from families

Click **Messages** to see notes sent through the Contact form. You can mark one read, delete it, or reply. These messages also land in your regular email inbox, so you can always reply from there too.

Your Excel download is your spreadsheet now

The “**Download list for Excel**” button gives you exactly the sheet you've always kept, column for column: **tNo** (the pickup number), the applicant, their address, the **Special Gift** column (each person's gift requests and any doll choices), **adopted**, **Thanksgiving**, **Food Card/Cert.** and its amount, **Gift Cards** and their amount, and the **number in the household**. Pick a town first and the download covers just that town — handy for handing a distributor their day's list.

Next to it, a second button — “**Download everything (backup)**” — gives the full-detail version: phone numbers, income as reported, every household member and size, your private notes, and more. That one is for safekeeping and for the audit, not for handing around.

You really can't break it

It asks before anything permanent. Deleting always shows an “Are you sure?” question first, and every delete — applications, people, jobs, donors, messages, pickup days — gives you an **Undo** button right afterward.

Even a missed Undo isn't the end. If you delete an application and leave the page before pressing Undo, scroll to the bottom of *Applications this year*: a **Removed applications** list holds everything you've deleted this season, each with a **Put it back** button.

Your work saves immediately. When you press Save, it's saved.

And it's all written down. Every change you make to an application is noted automatically in its History list — so if you ever wonder “did I already fix this?” or the auditors ask what happened, the answer is right at the bottom of the page.

The old ways still work. The message phone line and the paper application remain, so no family is ever left out.

The only thing to be careful with: the private information families share is theirs alone. Only sign in on a computer you trust, and sign out when you're on a shared or public one.

If you ever get stuck

Nothing is urgent and nothing is your fault — websites just have quirks sometimes. If something doesn't look right, jot down what you were doing and reach out for a hand:

Who to contact: **Cody Schluenz**

Phone: **425-765-7609** · Email: **codydps@gmail.com**